



Annual Impact Report

EmpowerHer 2024-2025

The EmpowerHer Team

December 1st, 2025





Introduction

EmpowerHer is a youth-led initiative founded by Nahid Karimi and Mahdi Rahimi in the United States, dedicated to equipping Afghan girls and women with the tools, confidence, and opportunities to create meaningful change. Through creative arts, storytelling, education, leadership, and cultural exchange, EmpowerHer provides safe spaces for girls to express themselves, preserve their histories, and amplify their voices. EmpowerHer runs two key programs: the Mentorship Program, where students receive a month of free mentorship through workshops to develop skills, leadership, and networks for launching their own impact projects, and HerVoice, which gives girls a platform to share their stories and experiences.

The 2025 Annual Impact Report highlights the remarkable work achieved this year, including the number of students reached, workshops conducted, countries represented, and stories published by our participants. It also provides a glimpse into our growing team, new initiatives, and upcoming programs designed to empower even more Afghan girls in 2026.

By documenting our efforts and successes, this report aims to showcase the transformative impact of EmpowerHer on the lives of Afghan girls, celebrate their creativity and resilience, and share our vision for a future where every girl has the opportunity to learn, grow, and lead.



Mentorship Program

In 2024 – 2025, EmpowerHer directly reached **approximately 760 Afghan girls** across **14 provinces** (Kabul, Balkh, Ghazni, Badakhshan, Takhar, Kunar, Bamyán, Kandahar, Herat, Daykundi, Paktia, Wardak, Oruzgan, Sar-e-Pol, and Parwan) **in Afghanistan**. Our programs also connected girls from **six countries**, including Afghanistan, Iran, Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, and Tajikistan, fostering a diverse and international community of learners.

Workshops Delivered & Mentors/Lecturers

This year, EmpowerHer successfully conducted **five major workshops**, offering students opportunities to develop creative, leadership, and technical skills:

- **Creative Writing & Storytelling Workshop (CWS)**

Mentor: Nahid Karimi

Lecturer: Daniel Fletcher

- **Leadership & Personal Development Workshop (LPD)**

Mentor: Mahdi Rahimi

Lecturer: Orly Bloom

- **Creative Arts Workshop**

Mentor: Sabira Hussaini (Former Mentor)

Lecturer: Leo Martinez

- **HTML & CSS Coding Workshop**

Mentor: Sara Faizi

Lecturer: Atifa Annabi



- **Cultural Exchange & Language Learning Workshop (CELL)**

Mentors: [Hania Dziduszko & Leena Geloo](#)

Lecturer: [Joel Baca](#)

In addition, **new workshops** by two of our program assistants are set to launch in 2026, led by our program assistants, including:

- **Resume Building Workshop by Sarah Ghaznawi**
- **Communication & Public Speaking Workshop (CPS) by Atifa Annabi**





How Does EmpowerHer Select Its Students?

Eligibility & Selection Criteria

- Applicants must be Afghan girls residing in Afghanistan or other Middle Eastern / Central Asian countries.
- Candidates must have intermediate or advanced English proficiency.
- While there is no strict age limit, EmpowerHer prefers applicants aged 14 and above.
- Programs are open only to girls; men are not eligible.

Application & Workshop Structure

- Interested students apply to a specific workshop under EmpowerHer's Mentorship Program.
- Each workshop runs over a 4-week cycle, with two 1.5-hour sessions per week.
- To maintain quality and personalized attention, each workshop accepts a maximum of 16 participants.

Note: Our mentors carefully read, review, and re-review each applicant's materials, evaluating eligibility and ability based on the student's essays and the strength of their creativity. Essays are the most important part of the application and play the biggest role in determining whether a student is accepted into the program.



Roadmap to Our Students' Impact Project

EmpowerHer provides a clear pathway for students to grow from workshop participants to leaders within our mentorship program.

Step 1

Complete Two Workshops in a Row

Students who successfully complete two workshops consecutively and meet attendance and assignment requirements will receive a Certificate of Completion for their workshops.

Step 2

Express Interest & Apply

After completing two workshops, students who wish to become EmpowerHer Assistants should express their interest by emailing apply@empowerher-initiative.org. Applicants will be interviewed to assess their skillsets and language proficiency.

Step 3

Assistant Application & Onboarding

Successful candidates are welcomed as Assistants for two workshop cycles, gaining hands-on experience supporting new participants and learning how a nonprofit operates. During this period, they also prepare their own online workshop to mentor other Afghan girls.

Step 4

Academic Demo & Promotion to Mentorship

Towards the end of their Assistant training, students conduct an Academic Demo Session, mentoring a staff member to demonstrate their teaching and leadership skills. After successfully completing the demo, Assistants are promoted to Mentor positions, officially joining the EmpowerHer Mentorship Program and mentoring even more Afghan girls.



HerVoice Publishing & Writing Outcomes

HerVoice is EmpowerHer’s creative storytelling platform where students — especially those in the Creative Writing & Storytelling Workshop — publish original pieces and share their personal journeys with a global audience. It offers a safe space for Afghan girls to express their challenges, hopes, and resilience, while following clear submission guidelines, such as including a relevant image and keeping essays 900–1000 words or poems under 40 lines. Through partnerships with NSHSS and Amplify Afghan Women, HerVoice amplifies stories that are often silenced by war, displacement, and oppression, turning personal experiences into powerful narratives. This year, EmpowerHer supported students in publishing their work across multiple platforms.

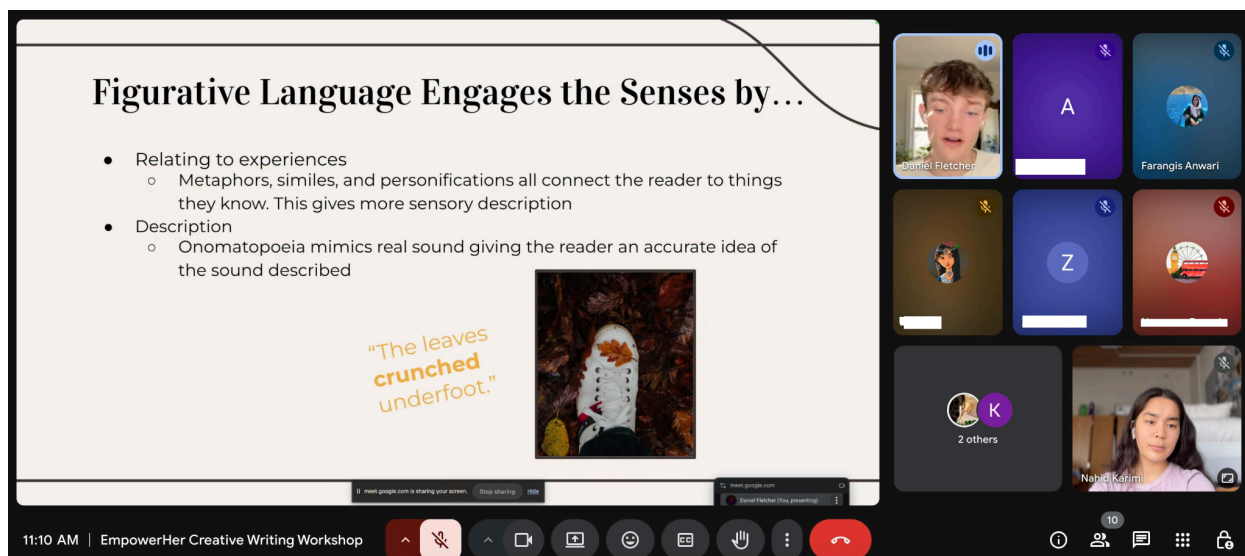
- 1 piece of writing published in [Rappahannock News](#)
- 8 writings published on [Amplify Afghan Women](#)
- 4 writings published on [NSHSS platforms](#)
- 7 writings published on the [HerVoice Platform](#)

Note: You can also have access to all of our writings published by our publication partners through this link: [Featured Writings from Our Partners](#)

In total, **20 student pieces** were published this year, allowing Afghan girls to share their voices, stories, and perspectives with wider audiences.



Community Building & Global Impact



Creative Writing and Storytelling Workshop (CWS)

EmpowerHer continues to cultivate a safe, supportive community for Afghan girls both locally and internationally. Although our programs are entirely online, we have been able to foster a sense of togetherness through consistent virtual meetings and follow ups both for our students and staff members.

This year: Girls connected with mentors and educators from around the world, gaining guidance in leadership, writing, and creative expression. Our team is composed of diverse backgrounds and countries such as Poland, Peru, Afghanistan, Pakistan, and the United States. We aim to expand on our staff numbers as needed.

- Students developed skills in digital literacy, confidence-building, and storytelling, allowing them to preserve Afghan history and culture.
- By providing a platform for voices that are often silenced, EmpowerHer ensures that participants can share narratives that matter, even under challenging circumstances.



Student Reviews about EmpowerHer

HTML & CSS Workshop

“This workshop was exciting and truly empowering for me. I never imagined I could design my own portfolio website, but practicing the codes step by step helped me believe in my abilities. I loved seeing all my personal information organized on a website I created myself. It made me feel confident and motivated to continue learning more about technology.” - **HTML & CSS Mentee**

Creative Writing & Storytelling Workshop (CWS)

“This workshop gave me hope and taught me how to face challenges with creativity. I found my voice through storytelling and poetry, and sharing my thoughts made me more confident. Every session brought something new, and working with other girls helped me improve my writing in ways I never expected.” - **CWS Mentee**

Leadership & Personal Development Workshop (LPD)

“This workshop changed the way I see myself as a leader. The real-life examples inspired me to believe I can create positive change, even through small acts. I learned confidence, communication, and the importance of active listening. The mentors created a safe space where I felt supported, and I now feel ready to guide others in my community.” - **LPD Mentee**

Cultural Exchange & Language Learning Workshop (CELL)

“This workshop was my first real experience with cultural exchange, and it was an amazing journey. I learned so much about global art, society, and traditions while also sharing my own culture with confidence. The assignments inspired my creativity, and the discussions helped me understand the world better. The mentors were so supportive, and I left feeling more connected and hopeful.” - **CELL Mentee**

Creative Arts Workshop

“This workshop helped me express emotions I could never put into words. Creating art from my own story made me feel seen and gave me confidence. It wasn’t just about drawing — it helped me find my voice and believe in my abilities.” - **Creative Arts Mentee**

Note: Due to EmpowerHer’s privacy policy, terms, and security measures, the names of students will not be shared and will be kept strictly confidential.



Message from the Executive Team

This year has been a powerful reminder of the creativity, resilience, and determination of Afghan girls. As a youth-led initiative, EmpowerHer is deeply proud of the growth we witnessed across all our programs: from storytelling and leadership to coding, cultural exchange, and the arts. Each workshop, each published story, and each connection made reflects our mission to create spaces where girls can learn, express themselves, and lead with confidence.

We are inspired by the dedication of our mentors, lecturers, volunteers, and staff who continue to guide our students with compassion and purpose. Most importantly, we celebrate the courage of every girl who joined EmpowerHer this year and trusted us with her voice, her dreams, and her story.

To the Afghan girls we serve: your strength is shaping a future that once seemed impossible, and we will continue to stand beside you as you rise.

As we look toward 2025-2026, we remain committed to expanding opportunities, strengthening our global community, and amplifying Afghan girls' voices on even larger platforms. Together, we will continue building a future where every girl has the chance to rise, create, and lead.

Nahid Karimi & Mahdi Rahimi

EmpowerHer Executive Team





Contact Information and Important Links

For further inquiries or support, please reach out to EmpowerHer:

- General Information: info@empowerher-initiative.org
- Mentorship Program Applications or Questions: apply@empowerher-initiative.org
- HerVoice Inquiries: hervoice@empowerher-initiative.org
- Website: www.empowerher-initiative.org
- Volunteer With Us: [Link](#)
- Partner With Us: [Link](#)
- Subscribe to our newsletter: [Link](#)
- [Instagram](#) | [Facebook](#) | [LinkedIn](#) |